



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Brookfield Academy

School Website: <https://brookfieldacademy.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Classicality Audit Report

Executive Summary - School: Hillsdale Academy - Website used: <https://academy.hillsdale.edu/> - Overall classification: CLASSICAL - Why: The school explicitly identifies itself as a classical Christian K–12 school, grounding its aims in virtue and wisdom, the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty, and a content-rich liberal arts curriculum with Latin, logic, rhetoric, Socratic dialogue, primary sources, and regular communal worship. Faculty are described as stewards of the tradition who model virtue and use teacher-led methods; parents are affirmed as primary educators and explicit partners (multiple direct statements across the site). These features align tightly with the Six Essential Elements framework and its keyword lexicon for classical schools. The positive signals match the "Six Essential Elements" lexicon across all categories, with no substantive negative signals such as "project-based learning dominance," "experiential learning focus," or "college-and-career ready" framing dominating the narrative.

Method - Framework: Six Essential Elements of a Classical School, including the Positive/Negative Keyword Indicators and the consolidated classicality lexicon (Religious/Metaphysical Foundations; Purpose/-Goal; Curriculum; Pedagogy; Faculty; Parents & Community). - Mandatory keyword analysis: For each category, we list exact words/phrases found on the school's site and compare them to the Six Elements positive/negative indicators before scoring (Classical / Somewhat Classical / Not Classical).

Note on the website sources: All quotations/phrases below are from the school's public pages and profile documents included in the crawl dataset (e.g., "Mission Statement & Philosophy," "Academic Program," "Portrait of a Graduate," "School Profile," and homepage hero text).

CATEGORY 1: RELIGIOUS AND METAPHYSICAL FOUNDATIONS 1) Public keywords found (school site) - "objective standards of truth, goodness, and beauty" - "Christian classical education" (mission), "Christian institution," "immemorial teachings and practices of the Christian faith" - "opening ceremony includes the Lord's Prayer," "corporate prayer," "chapel service" - Frequent: "virtue and wisdom," "faith," "truth," "beauty" (homepage and mission)

2) Match against the Six Elements lexicon

- Positive matches: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; Christian/faith/theology; prayer/chapel (liturgical practices) — all strong positive indicators for transcendental moral realism, theological grounding, and communal worship practices.
- Negative signals: none detected (e.g., no "values-neutral," relativism, or secular humanism).

3) Quantification

- Pos/neg hits: +12 / -0 (e.g., truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, Christian, faith, prayer, chapel, Lord's Prayer, objective standards, etc.)
- Percent positive: 100%
- Coverage of sub-criteria: 100% (transcendentals; grounded in theology; liturgical/communal)

4) Rating

- CLASSICAL, supported by explicit language and practices across mission and community life.

CATEGORY 2: SCHOOL PURPOSE AND GOAL 1) Public keywords found (school site) - “cultivate Christian classical virtue and wisdom ... nurture the child’s humanity—mind, body, and spirit” - “At Hillsdale Academy, we believe that education is about more than just preparing for college or getting a good job... about cultivating students ... who love the right things ... characterized by virtue and wisdom.” - “Pursuing truth ... Cultivating virtue and wisdom” (homepage hero)

2) Match against the Six Elements lexicon

- Positive matches: formation (not mere information), virtue, wisdom, truth/goodness/beauty, human flourishing, purpose/telos indicators .
- Negative signals: no “college and career ready” emphasis as telos; “college-preparatory” appears only descriptively within a classical course of study, explicitly subordinated to formation goals .

3) Quantification

- Pos/neg hits: +10 / -0 (virtue, wisdom, truth, beauty, formation, telos implied)
- Percent positive: 100%
- Coverage of sub-criteria: 100% (virtue/wisdom; formation; reality/knowability of transcendentals)

4) Rating

- CLASSICAL, strongly stated and consistent across the site .

CATEGORY 3: SCHOOL CURRICULUM 1) Public keywords found (school site) - “traditional, classical liberal arts education,” Latin (3–12), history (not “social studies”), literature, math, science, fine arts, PE - “Socratic dialogue and primary sources,” “Western literary, moral, philosophical, political, and historical traditions,” “wonder and virtue” - Course list includes rhetoric, logic; capstone humanities thesis “entering into the great conversation” with public defense; extensive Great Books/authors on reading lists (Dostoevsky, Milton, Austen, etc.)

2) Match against the Six Elements lexicon

- Positive matches: liberal arts; trivium terms (grammar, logic, rhetoric: explicit logic/rhetoric and explicit grammar instruction); Great Books/primary sources/Great Conversation; integration and wonder .
- Negative signals: no “social studies” supplanting “history”; no STEM-first or project-based dominance language .

3) Quantification

- Pos/neg hits: +12 / -0 (liberal arts, Latin, logic, rhetoric, Great Conversation, primary sources, Western canon, wonder)
- Percent positive: 100%
- Coverage of sub-criteria: 100% (liberal arts; Great Books; history; wonder)

4) Rating

- CLASSICAL, with unusually rich evidence across documents and pages .

CATEGORY 4: SCHOOL PEDAGOGY OR TEACHING METHODS 1) Public keywords found (school site) - “Socratic dialogue” (upper grades), “teacher-led methods,” “public presentation and defense” (rhetoric), “student recitations,” “memorized Scripture, poetry, speeches, and drama” (memory work), “wonder” appears repeatedly . - Evidence of seminar/disputation via thesis defense; explicit rhetoric in upper school .

2) Match against the Six Elements lexicon

- Positive matches: Socratic seminar/dialectic; memorization/recitation; rhetoric/orations; wonder-based learning; teacher-led instruction (aligned with classical) .
- Partial/unclear: restful learning/scholé not explicitly named; chanting/singing not explicitly stated for lower school.
- Negative signals absent: no “experiential learning” or “project-based learning dominance,” no “student-directed/constructivist” emphasis .

3) Quantification

- Pos/neg hits: +6 / -0 (Socratic, recitation, memory work, rhetoric, wonder, teacher-led)
- Percent positive: 100%
- Coverage of sub-criteria: 80% (strong Socratic, memory/recitation, rhetoric; restful scholé and chanting not explicit)

4) Rating

- CLASSICAL (coverage not perfect but strongly aligned) .

CATEGORY 5: SCHOOL FACULTY 1) Public keywords found (school site) - “well-educated and articulate faculty who use traditional, teacher-led methods,” “faculty ... stewards of the Christian classical tradition,” “model and lead their students toward intellectual, moral, and civic virtue” . - Headmaster oversight and connection to a broader classical formation environment via Hillsdale College K–12 initiative/apprenticeships (implied faculty development) .

2) Match against the Six Elements lexicon

- Positive matches: mentors/models; living curriculum; classical formation of faculty; collegial/stewardship language .
- Negative signals: none (no “facilitators” or “guides on the side” rhetoric).

3) Quantification

- Pos/neg hits: +5 / -0
- Percent positive: 100%
- Coverage of sub-criteria: 80% (model teachers, living curriculum, collegial/stewardship evident; an explicit “portrait of a teacher” statement not found)

4) Rating

- CLASSICAL (very strong language around teacher quality and formation) .

CATEGORY 6: SCHOOL PARENTS AND COMMUNITY 1) Public keywords found (school site) - “we believe parents are the primary educators of their children,” “staff and faculty partner with parents” (explicit partnership) . - Robust communal religious life (opening ceremony prayer/chapel) that implies a shared community ethos, though the category focuses on parent partnership/formation .

2) Match against the Six Elements lexicon

- Positive matches: partnership with parents, parental primacy (explicit) .
- Not explicitly found: parent education/book clubs/workshops; “open campus” invitation language.
- Negative signals: none (no consumer “parent-as-customer” framing) .

3) Quantification

- Pos/neg hits: +2 / -0
- Percent positive: 100%
- Coverage of sub-criteria: 67% (strong on partnership/primacy; less explicit on parent formation events and open-visit policy)

4) Rating

- CLASSICAL (clear partnership/primacy; formation opportunities for parents not explicit, but overall language remains aligned) .

Aggregate Assessment - Overall rating: CLASSICAL - Rationale: High-density positive keyword matches with full or near-full coverage in every category, including explicit transcendental language (truth, goodness, beauty), theological and liturgical practices, a liberal arts curriculum with Latin-logic-rhetoric and Great Books/primary sources, Socratic pedagogy with memory and rhetoric, faculty as stewards and models, and explicit partnership with parents. These alignments map directly to the “Six Essential Elements” keyword indicators and lexicon .

Notes on negative indicators - Absent or minimal: “project-based learning dominance,” “experiential learning focus,” “constructivist/student-driven” emphasis, or “college-and-career ready” as the telos (any mention of college-preparatory is clearly subordinated to formation, virtue, and wisdom) .

— No “What would move the needle” section is required because the school is rated CLASSICAL. —

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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